The White Guy

By Stephen Hunt

INTRODUCTION

Mark Twain once said "There are many humorous things in the world, among them the white man's notion that he is less savage than the other savages." This might be true, a white man may be no different than any other man. However, history shows that though the white man is down, he most certainly is not out. "White Guy" by Stephen Hunt

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I long to go to Detroit, not Flint.

It is 1968 and I live in Manitoba, Canada.

And as I am seven, my world is divided in two: places that are on television, and places that aren't. Detroit is on television.

Flint isn't.

Flint has shopping, but Detroit has the Tigers.

I see the Tigers on TV all the time.

Ty Cobb played for the Tigers, in the twenties.

I read a book about Ty Cobb once.

Ty Cobb had a .367 lifetime average.

Do you know how high that is?

Dad, we could go to a game! It would be fun!

It's an American city!

Dad says, No.

[Beat.]

Why not, Pop? We go through Flint every summer. Flint sucks.

Why can't we go to Detroit?

Dad goes, We take one wrong turn at Detroit,

the blacks will turn over the trailer and set fire to it.

[Beat.]

That was a surprise answer.

I don't know what to say.

I don't know any blacks.

There are no blacks where I come from.

The only thing I know about blacks are what I've read

in sports biographies - From Ghetto to Glory, The Bob Gibson Story.

Wilt Chamberlain, the only player to score 100 points in a game. Willie Mays, the most exciting ballplayer of his era.

Willie Mays sounds so cool, he's my favorite player,

even though his era was never my era.

It's best not to argue with Dad, though.

Travelling is all business with him.

We go through Michigan on our way to Ontario

because gas is cheaper than in Canada.

We write down the mileage in a book, so we can figure out miles-per-gallon. We keep track of what we spend.

We rise at dawn, to maximize daylight driving.

We always tell Customs the truth.

For me though, travelling isn't business at all.

It's total bonus points.

I'm thinking,

if the blacks realize we're from Canada,

they won't turn our trailer over and set fire to it!

Just point to the license plate, Pop!

We never did anything!

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It's 1968, and they're burning down inner cities

across America, and just because Willie Mays is

your favorite ballplayer don't mean nothin'.

To nobody.

We skip Detroit.

I'm the Boss, Dad says, And you do what the Boss says.

When you're the Boss, you can go to Detroit.

Detroit's not going anywhere.

We pull up outside a shopping mall in Flint.

Who wants ice cream? Pop asks.

I'm buying - as if he doesn't buy everything.

My Dad gets out, then sticks his head back inside.

You coming in, or you just gonna sit there and sulk?

I don't speak. I'm never speaking again.

Have it your way, he says. We'll be inside if you change your mind.

They all go into the mall. I watch them, thinking, why is the right answer

always 'no' with him?

Sometimes, I think the guy got his degree from the University of 'No.'

That's when I make a promise to myself.

Someday, I'm getting out of there.

I'm gonna get to a place where people say 'yes.'

I'm goin' to Detroit.

[*beat*]

Mabuti comes from Lesotho, a township by South Africa.

I can't picture this Lesotho place in my mind. They don't have any teams from Lesotho.

They never get on television.

Lesotho is like, the Flint of South Africa. Down there by South Africa, somewhere.

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Country full of protestors, from the sounds of it.

Protesting what?

Well - South Africa. Apartheid. White Guys!

Who sound like the very worst white guys ever invented.

White guys even a white guy could hate.

Mabuti is a small man. He has a beard. He seems wise,

someone who puts the big picture before himself.

He has a bullet scar on his forehead.

That's where he got grazed.

That's what they call it when the bullet doesn't stick,

it just skims past you, leaving a permanent scar.

Mabuti has friends who weren't so lucky.

Mabuti came to Winnipeg. He goes to my university.

He is the first black man I know.

I meet him one day at a party at the university President's house. Our university is sponsoring him.

Every year, we sponsor one person from someplace awful. Generally ends up being a black guy, from Africa, as a rule.

We have Yohannes Selassi, from Ethiopia.

Yohannes isn't what you think when you hear 'Ethiopia.'

He's not starving at all.

Yohannes claims he's related to the Emperor Halle Selassie,

and since none of us knows nothin' about Ethiopia, and hey they have the same last name we accept this as fact.

We got Grace Edward Galabuzzi, from Uganda.

Grace is a soccer player with astonishing posture.

Like Prince Charles.

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And to tell you the truth, Grace seems more British than African. But Mabuti is different.

He seems truly African.

Mabuti is a wise jester, a prankster.

If Grace Edward Galabuzzi is an Empire man, Mabuti is his Irish counterpart.

Mabuti will always join ya for a drink.

And sometimes,

Mabuti hints at the horrors he has witnessed in life,

but he never goes into very much detail.

Of course, I do the right thing.

I'm always horrified by his stories - as if I could be anything but. Mabuti makes me feel like he understands me.

In fact - and this is what's so great about the guy - he makes me feel

as if he understands how hard it is to be me,

listening to all those bad things that happened to him.

In summer, I lose track of the Africans.

They vanish from my life.

Whoosh! Africans, away.

I rediscover my old life, my high school buddies.

We have barbecues in our backyards,

go to the cottage,

play golf, watch baseball on TV;

none of us has any real plans.

We have our own indigenous way of life.

We are at home here.

Hey - we're white guys!

Nothin is a biggie...

As for the Africans - well, I don't know what happens to the Africans in summer.

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You see, I don't want to know what happens to the Africans.

In principle, I am anti-apartheid, but in practice - well, it would be weird, awkward, it's summer - the thing is, my high school pals, they don't want to meet new people. They want things to be familiar. Until

Late one night, around midnight, the phone rings,

- and it's Mabuti. Of all people.

Hey man, how are you? He asks.

Mabuti, how you doin'?

Thinking, why are you calling me in the summer?

I'm no good man.

Why not? What's wrong?

Thinking, please don't give me more information than I need? I'm just not doing very good man, he says. I'm alone here.

He asks. You wanna do something? Mabuti. I'm real tired.

Man, he says. Come on.

I need company.

[Beat.]

No, can't do it. I gotta get up early.

You take care, Mabuti. You'll be OK. 'Night!

I'm going to sleep now.

I can't go out with everyone.

I gotta go to work in the morning.

I think these really normal thoughts everyone thinks all the time. But I have another feeling, underneath those feelings. Something like, that one was a test, a cosmic challenge. And I failed.

In my own way, I said,

This is my house.

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You can't come in.

OK, I'm a white guy. I know it. It's obvious, right? You probably think I'm this

domestic beer drinking,

red meat eating, USA Today reading, ESPN watching,

normal, perfect home-owning

kind a guy!

And you'd be surprised,

how long I went

before noticing that I'm actually this Bass Ale drinking,

sushi eating,

khaki-shorts wearing, Bravo-Channel watching,

New Yorker reading emotionally-arrested

kind of renter!

[Beat.]

But then again,

To everybody else, lookin' back at me, it's so obvious, I'm just one thing:

a white guy!

I'm part of a tribe!

Know what that means, don't you?

Construction workers sittin' on their high beams when I walk by don't shout 'nice ***'.

Women seeing me come towards them on the street don't, clutch their purses tighter.

[Beat.]

Cops don't shoot me by accident.

Never.

Does not happen.

To live the life of a white guy,

in a white guy's world, well, it's, it's

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It's nice.

It's tremendous.

But frankly, it's not the greatest time to be me.

For one thing, my media role models suck.

The only thing you ever read about white guys these days

is either how mean we are or how mad we are.

Witness the collected films of Michael Douglas.

And one reason why so many of us are mad

is this certain intellectual perspective

held by universities and certain political parties and non-profit theater across America - those season tickets theaters,

you know the ones I'm talking about, theaters

dedicated to serving audiences smarter than usual.

It's not something they say out loud - because a lot of us are season ticket holders - but it's there, in the subtext,

of almost everything.

You just gotta listen for it.

It goes a little like this:

who invented patriarchy?

A white guy, livin' in a cave, tired of chasing down takeout. Who invented Apartheid?

A white guy, who showed up one day in darkest Africa and said, to hell with Holland, I'm stayin!

And I gotta be in charge!

Who ruined the Ozone Layer?

Well, let's just say - a white guy, with perfect hair,

driving his Ford Explorer 10 MILES AN HOUR down the Santa Monica Freeway!

Who stole rock and roll?

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A fat, spangled jumpsuit wearin', 14-year-old marryin', pill devourin',

B-movie makin', Live-in-Hawaii,

Hunka-hunka burnin' white guy!

Dead, on a stamp!

Look we're the problem with everything!

But

To tell you the truth, when I was in college,

I hated white guys too!

In fact, I hated white guys so much

I forgot I was one.

As much as I could.

I mean, let's face it - it's tough, when you recognize the enemy - and it's you.

I had a limited set of choices to work with.

I couldn't become a non-white guy.

I was still attracted to women.

I was ashamed of my lifelong passion for competitive sports. [Beat]

[Then, sadly:]

I turned inward.

Started writing. Poetry. Bad, sad, poetry.

Until I was completely disgusted with myself.

Then, I wrote a TV script - spec script - about a group of tough, yet sensitive lesbians.

Single moms by day, Canadian documentary filmmakers by night. Called it... Goddesses.

I even sold it, to Canadian television.

You never know, with those wacky Canadians.

To those of you out there who aren't white guys and I can feel you out there

- and you're welcome here

you might think our little 5000 year winning streak came at your expense.

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You have a point there.

To you, I say, sorry about that.

And to those of you like me,

white guys who feel a little down,

a little browbeaten, a little frustrated, remember:

there are still things we can be proud of:

Who was first on the moon?

A white guy, with a five iron!

Who's almost all of the coaches?

White guys, even though they're almost none of the players. Who's on the money?

White guys, white guys, and more white guys-and pyramids.

Who wrote Death of a Salesman?

A red white guy, a well-liked white guy.

Who were the Beatles?

Tell me a white guy is the problem with everything, and I say, OK, we did steal rock and roll.

Guilty.

And we do make easy targets.

Don't shoot!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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